

Creating business value through corporate communication

A theory-based framework and its practical application

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to report on a multi-step research project which explores concepts that explain communication value across different disciplines and builds a framework that identifies and systematizes communication goals linked to generic corporate goals.

Design/methodology/approach – Based on a literature review of work on value creation through communication, drawn from 815 publications in 36 international journals across several disciplines (public relations, marketing, management, etc.) and published from the year 2000 onward, the authors have developed a framework, named “Communication Value Circle.” The application of the framework was discussed with chief communication officers from global companies and was used during a communication alignment process in a global healthcare company.

Findings – Empirical surveys across several continents show that communication professionals use a multitude of rationales to explain the value of their work to top executives. These range from building reputation, brands and identity, to gaining thought leadership, boosting sales, motivating employees, preventing crises and listening to stakeholders. The researchers have identified four major value dimensions of communication (enabling operations, building intangibles, adjusting strategy, and ensuring flexibility). The framework encompasses 12 specific goals for communication that can be derived from corporate strategy.

Research limitations/implications – The framework stimulates the debate on the diverse concepts of communication value, performance and measurement, and the need to integrate those approaches into theory and practice. Additional qualitative studies to verify the framework are proposed.

Practical implications – The communication value circle can be used as a management tool for planning, evaluating, and revising strategic directions for communication in any corporation.

Originality/value – Explaining the value of communication continues to be one of the most important challenges for professionals and scholars alike. This paper proposes a consistent explanation for the theory and practice of what constitutes corporate communication.

Keywords Organizational effectiveness, Corporate communication, Measurement, Organizational performance, Communication management, Communication excellence, Communication goals, Communication planning

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

One of the key characteristics of corporate communication is its mission to serve the overall strategic goals of a company (Argenti, 2016; Goodman and Hirsch, 2015; Van Riel and Fombrun, 2007). However, linking communication to business strategy continues to be one of the key challenges for communication professionals around the globe. Recent surveys among more than 4,200 practitioners in 82 countries across Asia-Pacific (Macnamara *et al.*, 2015), Europe (Zerfass *et al.*, 2015), and Latin America (Moreno *et al.*, 2015) have identified this topic as the most or second-most significant issue for the profession in next years. Along these lines, 4,483 professionals in the USA and other large economies around the world interviewed for the Global Study of Leadership in Public Relations and Communication Management, ranked “improving the measurement of communication effectiveness to prove value” as among the four most relevant issues in the field (Berger and Meng, 2014). Empirical studies have also shown that practitioners lack a consistent



understanding of communication value as they use a multitude of rationales to explain the value of communication to top executives, ranging from building reputation and brands, gaining thought leadership and preventing crises, to stimulating sales or employee motivation (Macnamara *et al.*, 2015). As such, the obvious gap between the need to demonstrate value and the absence of practice might be related to the conceptual lack of a “big picture” of value creation in corporate communication – and not solely limited to inadequate practices of measurement and evaluation on an applied level, as claimed by many scholars and practitioners (Stacks and Michaelson, 2014; Watson and Noble, 2014).

Therefore, we propose a new approach to close this gap. Rather than arguing from the perspective of the corporate communication function and looking for yet another magic formula for communication value, we suggest starting with a reflection on corporate strategy and its generic contribution to business goals. This corresponds with the idea that strategic communication is neither limited to the activities of communication departments nor to specific stakeholders or situations. Instead, communication is a cross-sectional function that aims to fulfill the organization’s mission in many different ways (Christensen and Cornelissen, 2011; Holtzhausen and Zerfass, 2015; Nothhaft, 2010). In this respect it is necessary to understand the different facets of value creation in corporations, as well as the multitude of concepts on the contribution of communication to organizational goals (Pallas and Svensson, 2016). Both strands must be aligned to develop a comprehensive framework of corporate communication value.

This paper describes the process, results, and implications of this research approach. It reports on the extensive literature survey that has been conducted in order to build the framework; explains the framework named communication value circle and its dimensions; and shows how this framework can be applied in practice. The limitations and requirements for future research are also outlined. The results presented here are based on a multi-step research project conducted by communication and management researchers from two universities, and supported by a sounding board of chief communication officers from several global blue-chip companies.

Literature review

The first task of this research was to identify and systematize the various theoretical concepts on value creation through communication that were present in the academic literature. We conducted a literature review in the disciplines of corporate communication, organizational communication, public relations, marketing, and strategic management. The review focused on publications written in English and German (the two most important *linguae francae* of the social sciences) since the year 2000. We used multiple search terms to identify relevant contributions through an iterative multi-step process, relying on electronic database searches (Business Source Complete, Communication Mass Media Complete), manual searches in leading academic journals, cross-reference and citation tracking in landmark works, as well as web searches on popular practitioners’ blogs and industry associations’ websites. The 18 search terms employed included: measurement, evaluation, controlling, reputation, value, audit(ing), scorecard, assets, strategy map, effectiveness, listening, audience, brand, intangibles, contribution, monitoring, impact, and effect. Different types of contributions were deemed relevant for the review and these included journal articles located in 36 international journals, seminal books, and reference works in the field (e.g. Kaplan and Norton, 1996, 2004; Kotler and Keller, 2012; Pfannenberger and Zerfaß, 2010; Porter, 1985; Rappaport, 1986; Stacks and Michaelson, 2014; Watson and Noble, 2014), as well as industry whitepapers and standpoints (e.g. International Association for the Measurement and Evaluation of Communication, 2010, 2015). These searches resulted in a sample of 815 relevant contributions.

A qualitative content analysis of the publications (Hsieh and Shannon, 2005; Mayring, 2000) was conducted, relying on a systematic data extraction process with 24 analytical coding categories for general information (e.g. authors, affiliations, type of publication, year of publication), and specific information (e.g. topics under investigation, definitions, theoretical background, methodological approach), as well as the coders' comments and remarks (e.g. relation to value creation, critique, implications for framework). The review revealed that measuring the effects of communication in organizational contexts has been an important topic in communication research since the 1970s (Likely and Watson, 2013; Macnamara, 1992, 2002; Volk, 2016; Watson, 2012). Through inductive coding and searching for common patterns across the included evidence, different streams of research were identified and clustered and, finally, four major streams of research emerged. The first three streams represent different understandings of value creation and the fourth stream comprises various approaches to implementing goal-setting and measurement in communications.

The majority of the contributions aim at explaining the influence of corporate communication messaging on stakeholder attitudes and behavior. In the first research stream, value is conceptualized at an operational level as an effect of messaging. Researchers in marketing and public relations propose various models for clustering communicative outcomes into different chunks and levels of effects, such as media output, stakeholder awareness, attitudes, etc. (e.g. Kotler and Keller, 2012; Lindenmann, 2003; Macnamara, 2015). *Ex post* evaluation of corporate communication is intensively discussed in the realms of mass media, corporate media, and social media. These approaches aim to track links between communication and stakeholder behavior, for example, by influencing customer preferences or employee motivation. However, the questions of whether and how this contributes to organizational goals or strategy as a whole are seldom answered or measured. Instead, much of the literature based on this perspective assumes that communication is at the center of decision-making itself. This does not correspond with the reality of supporting functions in a business context. Moreover, many situational factors have to be taken into account when communicating and there are only a few circumstances (e.g. product launches) in which direct effects can be easily measured.

The second stream of research in the literature is related to the creation of intangible assets through communication. Here, value is defined strategically as a resource – as immaterial capital. Practitioners often use stories about soft factors created by communication to explain their job profiles to their superiors (Zerfass *et al.*, 2015). The key concepts introduced and discussed in the body of knowledge are reputation (Deephouse, 1997; Dowling, 2006; Fombrun, 1996), brands (Kapferer, 2012), corporate identity (Anson, 2000; Balmer and Greyser, 2006); employee commitment or motivation (de Bussy and Suprawan, 2012; Meng and Pan, 2012), organizational culture (Henri, 2006; Sackmann, 2006), relationships (Grunig, 2006; Hon and Grunig, 1999), networks (Eisenberg *et al.*, 2015; Esteves and Barclay, 2011), social capital (Sommerfeldt and Taylor, 2011), and communication capital (Malmelin, 2007). Raising awareness and changing the behavioral dispositions of stakeholders are described as drivers for creating intangible assets for corporations. There is also a large portfolio of methods to measure and value intangibles, such as reputation, brands, or social capital. In contrast to the popularity of these concepts, however, there are no standards for combining these closely linked values and for explaining their connection to organizational strategy.

Third, communication has been identified as a reflective function (Van Ruler and Verčič, 2005) that supports strategic alignment and positioning of corporations (Van Riel, 2012). Value is conceptualized strategically and proactively as a potential for future success. Recently, traditional concepts such as issues management (social) media monitoring and customer insights have been developed further in terms of the grand idea of building

architectures for organizational listening (Macnamara, 2016), which complement integrated messaging platforms and strategies (Van Riel and Fombrun, 2007). This underlines the notion that communication professionals can enable top executives, internal business partners, and employees (Heide and Simonsson, 2014; Mazzei, 2014) to perform better in their own areas of responsibility by widening their understanding of communicative prerequisites and the consequences of strategic decisions in the public sphere (Bentele and Nothhaft, 2010; Habermas, 1989). This relates to, but is not limited to, innovation, change, crises, and other contexts that are directly linked to corporate success (Frandsen and Johansen, 2011; Huang, 2012; Jin *et al.*, 2014; Pang, 2012; Watson *et al.*, 2002). To date, these concepts have not been linked to the predominant approaches of communication measurement and evaluation. Some researchers in this field might not even identify themselves with the paradigms of evaluation and continuous improvement. However, their research widens our understanding and they provide a valid explanation for the productive role of communication in organizations. The underlying conception of a communicative organization (Hamrefors, 2010) in which every member of the corporation is able to collaborate with stakeholders, is closely linked to the modern approaches of strategic management (Baber *et al.*, 2015) and the emerging concepts of the co-creation of value in stakeholder networks (Garriga, 2014).

The fourth important stream in the literature focuses on the adaptation of business valuation and management concepts. To date, many practitioners have attempted to measure the return on investment (ROI) in communication. However, the complexity of communication processes, the close nexus with other functions and activities, and a lack of transparency about costs and investments for communication in most corporations hinder the utilization of such indicators (Watson and Zerfass, 2011). Most of the concepts based on the ROI formula in academic research (e.g. Likely *et al.*, 2006; Meng and Berger, 2012) use a quasi-ROI blueprint that must not be confused with the original formula. Along these lines, recent approaches that try to define standard metrics for communication (International Association for the Measurement and Evaluation of Communication, 2015; Macnamara, 2014; Michaelson and Stacks, 2011), and seminal works in the field (Stacks and Michaelson, 2014; Watson and Noble, 2014), recommend measuring the impact on organizational performance but do not offer unified indicators or methods. Instead, they are open to different understandings of value, which can and should be combined at the operational and strategic levels. One example is the adaptation of management concepts such as scorecards and value links (Fleisher and Mahaffy, 1997; Hering *et al.*, 2004; Kaplan and Norton, 1996, 2004; Zerfass, 2008b). These enable professionals to visualize the link between communication activities, media and channel outcomes, changes in stakeholders' knowledge, attitude, behavioral disposition or behavior, and organizational impact. Based on these approaches, researchers and professional associations in German-speaking countries have developed a joint framework to capture the value chain of communication from input to outflow/impact (DPRG and ICV, 2011). Today, this framework is widely known and even accepted as a standard by many global corporations based in the region.

To sum up, to date, the question of how communication contributes to value creation for organizations has not been answered (Podnar *et al.*, 2009). Instead of providing a broad perspective of different value dimensions, researchers tend to keep to their specific fields of knowledge, such as crisis or innovation communication, measurement and evaluation, internal communication, etc. Additionally, professionals and researchers tend to focus on "soft factors", such as creating reputation, brands or relationships, even though these only represent one of the four outcomes of value creation through communication and are strongly influenced by circumstances beyond the control of the communication department. Although many indicators, measurement methods, and concepts for evaluation are available, they lead to different results and a coherent approach is lacking. De Beer (2014)

has called for “integrating the corporate communication process into strategic management, governance and value creation processes” (p. 136) to show and achieve benefits for the organization and also for society as a whole. This has been achieved by constructing a new holistic framework that combines the above-mentioned approaches.

Developing a new framework

Value-based management and communication

According to our literature review, most of the approaches to the contribution of communication to organizational goals begin by analyzing communication processes. However, it is not the capacity for corporate communication but the requirements of corporate strategy that should define the values to be supported or created (Argenti, 2016). Thus, it is important to begin by explaining what “value” means in the business world in general, before discussing the impact of effective communication.

Value creation describes the transformation of resources into goods or services with a higher financial value. This supports the foremost goal of every corporation – to work efficiently and effectively to create financial value today and enable value creation in the future. Value-based management is a well-known concept in business theory and practice, as explained in the studies by Porter (1985) and other management scholars. This concept means that all corporate decisions should focus on increasing the company’s overall value rather than only their short-term objectives. Corporate value was traditionally equated with shareholder value (Rappaport, 1986) and only measured in economic terms such as ROI. From this perspective, communication contributes to the overall value merely by positioning a company in the marketplace or by creating a favorable corporate image among investors. However, it is common knowledge today that corporate success not only depends on shareholders but also on sustainable relationships with employees, politicians, regulators, customers, mass media, social media influencers, and many other stakeholders. The concept of stakeholder value (Freeman, 1984) expands the notion of value-based management by considering the expectations and legitimate interests of everyone affected by corporate strategy. Thus, a corporation is positioned in the market, as well as within its social and political environments (Zerfass, 2008a).

In our understanding, the primary task of the communication function is to strategically manage and measure this positioning by using communicative means. In this sense, corporate communication is an integral part of a company’s value chain. Communication processes are part of the primary activities (inbound logistics, operations, outbound logistics, marketing and sales, and service), as well as the supporting activities (firm infrastructure, human resource management, technology, and procurement) (Porter, 1985). Thus, communication is not simply a function that helps top executives and other business managers to reach out to stakeholders. Corporate communication is also a valuable resource for listening and learning from the environment. It helps to reposition the organization and adjust strategies, and can be a key driver for creating an overall supportive framework for corporate activities.

Dimensions of value creation

In order to build a consistent typology of corporate and communication values we searched for approaches that describe generic goals for business success. Strategic management theory distinguishes liquidity (financial dimension), success (operational dimension: profitable business models), and potential for success (strategic dimension: resources that enable future success) (Gälweiler, 2005). In light of the stakeholder theory, these can be expanded and differentiated into four generic types of corporate values: tangible assets, intangible assets, room for maneuver, and opportunities for development. Tangible assets

include financial resources as well as goods and equipment that have a market value. They are needed to fulfill the demands of shareholders, investors, employees, suppliers, tax authorities, and others who interact with a corporation. This is very much linked to operations and the ongoing business model. Intangibles, on the other hand, are needed to deal with uncertainty, complexity, and future challenges. They may be based in daily operations, for example, positive aspects of reputation based on customer experiences. They can also be a result of specific investments, for example, patents or product brands. Room for maneuver is a value in itself since a corporation has to ensure that it gains and retains its license to operate (Van Riel, 2012). This may be threatened by regulators, politics, activists, the media, and several other actors. Last but not the least, development opportunities are valuable for organizations as they allow them to rebuild their business models and reposition themselves within their environment.

Corporate strategies prioritize and operationalize these four value dimensions into concrete goals based on the specific positioning and resources of a company (Porter, 1985; Steinmann *et al.*, 2013). Corporate management strives to accomplish these goals. As part of these overall ambitions, corporate communication can support all four dimensions. These dimensions in turn help to structure the multitude of communication goals identified in the literature. They can be summarized into 12 generic types of communication value and four dimensions of what communication actually does to support a corporation's value creation: enabling operations, building intangibles, ensuring flexibility, and adjusting strategy (see Figure 1). The goals for communication programs and campaigns can be

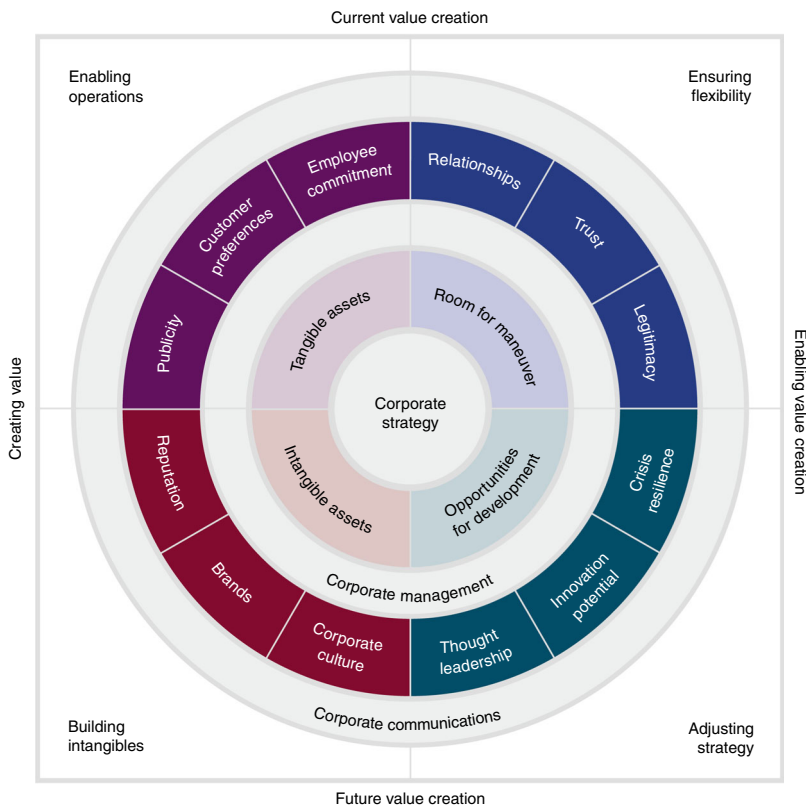


Figure 1.
The communication
value circle

categorized under these four dimensions and measured using the established sets of evaluation methods and performance indicators. However, due to the different characteristics of communication and corporate goals that contribute to stakeholder value, it is not possible to define an overall indicator and to calculate an overall value of communication – just as management theory and scorecard concepts have long abandoned the simplified idea of using only top indicators such as ROI to steer a company. Instead of presenting one key indicator or equation, the following framework serves as a template for prioritizing and planning communication activities.

The communication value circle

Description of the framework

A holistic approach to systematizing communication value needs to integrate various layers. It should also grasp the big picture. This requires a sophisticated visualization. Our proposal is shown in Figure 1: the communication value circle. This is an interdisciplinary framework that explains the process of value creation through communication at the levels of corporate strategy, corporate management, and corporate communication. The framework combines the generic value dimensions derived from the business literature with key insights from the body of knowledge on value creation through communication.

The core of the framework is the unique corporate strategy of the focal organization or unit (the overall enterprise on a global level, a specific business unit, a national subsidiary, etc.). Serving this strategy is the overall goal of all related business and communication activities. Depending on the strategy, corporate management will weigh the generic values discussed above in different ways. This is reflected in annual reports and statements to investors but, more importantly, in internal goals, budget allocations and incentive schemes. For example, a start-up company in the software industry will invest heavily in building up intangible assets such as a large customer base, a recognized brand, and securing its intellectual property rights across multiple markets. Generating profit (tangible assets) might be less important as daily operations are less dependent on cash flow than they are on the financial resources provided by key investors. Seeking new development opportunities by adjusting or enhancing the strategy will also be a key issue for start-ups. At the same time, they are usually not in the spotlight when it comes to challenging the legitimacy of labor relations or doing business in specific industries. Labor unions and non-governmental organizations tend to focus on establish brands and corporations when attacking an industry. In contrast, many established energy companies are now blessed with large intangible assets and a pipeline of innovative technologies such as hydraulic fracturing (“fracking”). Nevertheless, they struggle to secure their room for maneuver due to the changing western mindset toward energy consumption and production. This, in turn, makes it necessary to have a stronger focus than before on producing a satisfying amount of tangible assets and liquidity – an issue that had never been a limiting factor in the energy industry for decades. In any case, corporate communication contributes to value creation in all dimensions by achieving appropriate types of communication value.

The communication value circle is a matrix that can be read either vertically or horizontally. From the vertical perspective, tangible assets and intangible assets contribute to creating corporate value, whereas room for maneuver and opportunities for development contribute to enabling value creation. From the horizontal point of view, tangible assets and room for maneuver represent the corporation’s current value creation, whereas intangible assets and development opportunities foster future value creation. Every function within the corporation supports these four dimensions of corporate value on the first level of the framework. These generic values are applicable to human resource management, sales or, as in this case, corporate communication.

The 12 major values that can be achieved by corporate communication can be linked to the four core corporate values and the four dimensions of what constitutes communication for organizational success. These are as follows:

- (1) **Enabling operations:** communication contributes to organizational objectives by supporting business operations internally and externally, for example, through stimulating publicity, customer preferences, and employee commitment. By disseminating content and messages or by raising attention and awareness of strategic issues, communication keeps an organization running and enables the creation of material assets. By entering into dialogues with employees, suppliers, customers, etc., on a daily basis, communication builds the basis for delivering value to key stakeholders. Contributions to this first corporate value dimension appear to be critical when it comes to explaining and defending communication work to the management board since these assets build the basis of financial success and productivity.
- (2) **Building intangibles:** communication helps to create intangible assets, such as reputation, brands, or corporate culture. Intangibles are part of the overall value of the company. Reputation has to be managed for important representatives of the corporation (CEO communication), as well as for the whole company. Positive reputations and strong brands are not only relevant for the corporate environment, they also create a strong corporate identity. Integrating the specific culture and history of a corporation into its internal and external communications is a basic task for any communication department. Although this value proposition might be assumed to be the key asset of professional communication, the current and future worth of intangibles is influenced by many situational factors and organizational structures that cannot be controlled by the communication department. Thus, placing intangibles at the center of the communication department's value proposition could actually lead to an unexpected deprivation of power.
- (3) **Ensuring flexibility:** being flexible as a corporation means having relationships that are based on trust or, at least, a perception of the legitimacy of the corporation's values and actions. Communication can build stakeholder networks that ensure room for maneuver, and continue to do so in times of change and crisis. If the license to operate is questioned by relevant stakeholders every other value dimension will be negatively affected. Corporations have to face various situations of uncertainty, during which nothing becomes more important than relational capital, trust, and public acceptance. Although the process of ensuring flexibility through networks and relationships is a basic topic in public relations literature (Grunig, 2006; Hon and Grunig, 1999), the actual value of acceptance needs to be discussed in a more specific way. For example, there are almost no publications on how to plan or measure the legitimacy of a corporation's strategy.
- (4) **Adjusting strategy:** communication assists in making strategic management decisions by fostering thought leadership, innovation potential, and crisis resilience. This value dimension is built first and foremost on the communication department's capacity to listen. Systematically monitoring public opinion in mass media, social media, markets, politics, and society helps to adapt strategies to upcoming socio-political and economic developments. Thus, corporate communication contributes to identifying competitive advantages. By integrating this value proposition the researchers defend a specific perspective on the process of the strategic alignment of communication and management goals. The communication department's reflective function as a

boundary spanner is critical to corporate success. Although, the framework suggests a clear process of listening and of adjusting goals to serve the corporate strategy, communication professionals also need to question the strategic decisions of the management board in order to address the expectations and demands of various stakeholders and to ensure the company's future value creation.

Practical guidelines for using the framework

The communication value circle is first and foremost a tool for planning and prioritizing management and communication goals. The framework enables communication professionals to discuss their work with superiors and business partners. It provides a common platform by integrating concepts and approaches from the different perspectives of research and practice. Obviously, it is also fundamental that the corporate strategy has been defined and is known to those who are in charge of communications.

The framework should not be misunderstood as a normative representation of communication goals. Rather, it can help to align communication with the unique strategies of specific corporations or business units. In order to apply the communication value circle it is necessary to adapt the framework to the multitude of possible variables and situations in the business world, such as:

- type and size of corporations (start-up company, SME, corporate holding, etc.);
- functional areas and departments (communication department, marketing department, etc.);
- field of action (public affairs, public relations, innovation communication, etc.);
- stakeholders (customers, employees, journalists, etc.); and
- situational contexts (product launches, crises, post-merger integration, etc.).

As these variables change, so does the significance of the four dimensions of value creation. As mentioned above, strategies differ – even within the same company – depending on the scope and focus. Consequently, not every single communication goal is relevant for each function or department. For example, communication professionals working for a small start-up company might focus mainly on goals such as building a brand among customers and establishing a reputation among investors and potential partners. In contrast, a blue-chip corporation with a unique history and listed on the stock market can probably leverage the value of communication much more by adjusting strategies through a consistent system for corporate listening and thought leadership. At the same time, a subsidiary of the same listed corporation in another country could rank other values more highly, for example, supporting sales in the local market through consistent marketing communications and developing a culture of partnership with retailers on the ground. Depending on the goals to which they aspire, different structures and competencies are required. This shows that strategic corporate communication is inevitably linked to the core set-up, character, and identity of the focal organization, and any attempt to generically define the best ways in this field will miss the point.

Our framework can be used as a management tool to identify, discuss, structure, and agree on value drivers and performance indicators in corporate communication. It contributes to the strategic alignment of communication with overall organizational goals. Applying this tool helps to make corporate communication more transparent and manageable. Consequently, this can assist in improving the use and acceptance of communication measurement in corporate practice. A common understanding and comprehensible links to corporate strategy will make it easier to understand the relevance of such efforts.

Conclusion and future directions

We have argued that the continuing quest to explain the value of corporate communication might be supported by constructing a “big picture” that incorporates and systematizes the multitude of concepts and measurement methods used in various disciplines. An analytical approach based on an extensive literature survey was used to build such a framework – the communication value circle. Although the procedure had some limitations, it proved to be generally fruitful. Despite conducting an extensive literature review it was clearly not possible to include everything that has been written on the topic. A consequence of this was the omission of literature in languages other than English or German, literature published in other electronic databases, possible unpublished gray literature, and literature published prior to the 2000s, that is, early contributions about strategy and value creation. It would therefore be desirable to extend the review procedure to include other languages and other publication types, and especially literature from strategic management research and related research domains that were not considered in this analysis.

Clearly, it is necessary to test the applicability and usefulness this approach. To do so we invited a group of senior scholars in the fields of strategic management, marketing, human resources, reputation management, public relations, journalism, and chief communication officers from global companies headquartered in Germany, to comment on the framework during a one-day workshop in the fall of 2015. Moreover, the framework was tested in an applied research project with a global provider of healthcare products and services in 2015-2016. With 55,000 employees in 62 countries, the company achieves a turnover of approximately US \$6 billion. The framework was used to derive communication goals from the new global corporate strategy. It informed the construction of a strategic measurement system with value drivers and key performance indicators for the corporate communication department. Both exercises proved to be successful. The framework was generally approved and applicable. Comments and experiences were noted and were used to fine-tune the framework.

Future research is needed to prove the framework’s capacity to explain the links between communication and corporate goals on a broader scale. For this next step we propose qualitative case studies based on interviews and document analyses in corporations across different industries. In so doing, it will be necessary to identify specific combinations of corporate values, business goals and related indicators, stipulated goals for communication departments and their leaders, as well as the objectives assigned to communication activities and the methods of communication measurement and valuation. The case studies should help to verify or modify the communication value circle. Ultimately, it should be possible to use the framework to reconstruct empirical settings with the aim of describing specific approaches, identifying gaps, and outlining the best practices for value-creating communication in a common language. This in turn should contribute to the professionalization of corporate communication in both theory and practice.

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